



SPIRA DAS

MAMATA BANERJEE

Railways

Lady Reckless

Among the many feathers that don Mamata Banerjee's cap, sample this one: as a ruling party MP in 1996, she joined the Opposition to sit on a *dharna* inside the Lok Sabha over the government's decision to raise petroleum prices. In her second stint in the railway ministry, she has again broken convention by choosing to assume office, not in Rail Bhavan but at the Eastern Railway headquarters in Kolkata. If anything, it is proof that having taken her Trinamool Congress to its highest-ever tally, she now intends to focus more on derailing the Left Front than ensuring efficiency in the railways.

Priorities

- Proactive development schemes initially targeted towards her home state, West Bengal, will give her enough reasons to seek votes and help her oust the Left Front Government in the next assembly elections.
- Ensuring safety and security in trains. Introducing more trains nationwide to make the railways the real lifeline of the country.
- Open the Metro corridor for commuters, a project that she had launched in her previous stint as railways minister.

Is she the one? She will try her best to bring development to West Bengal with new packages and schemes, with an eye on the next assembly elections. That raises the question: how much will she be able to do for the railways? Her initial pronouncements are populist and oriented to benefit her own state but she is unlikely to repeat Lahu's revenue success. She is already showing signs that her mercurial attitude, political compulsions and ideology may become the UPA's biggest headache.

Style statement

Loves white, bordered Dhaniakhali cotton saris and only prefers *hawaii* chappals.

▼ 35%

PRAFUL PATEL

Civil Aviation

Cruising Speed

For a country with a proliferation of pilot politicians, it took a tobacco entrepreneur from the heartland of Maharashtra to turn the civil aviation sector into one of the great Indian success stories. This is one of the quirks that explains the rise of Praful Patel, 52. India's richest minister with a net worth of Rs 79.14 crore, he was among the most successful ministers in the last Cabinet, achieving a complete transformation in the sector.

Priorities

- Ensure airline safety by investing in state-of-the-art radars, communication and trained personnel.
- Strengthen regulatory structures by inducting fresh staff and collaborations with global aviation agencies.
- Turn around Indian, the loss-making combination of Air India and Indian Airlines.
- Continue to encourage investment in aviation infrastructure through innovative financing models like bonds.

Is he the one? Patel began his second innings with what sounded like a contradictory mantra: continuity with change. "Continuity of reforms and change in the dynamic aviation sector," he explains. In his first tenure, his open skies revolution turned a moribund sector around and delivered urban India's shiny new gateways. It seems hard to disregard his new resolve to tackle airline safety, strengthening regulatory structures and turning the national carrier around in his second term.

Style statement

Brioni suits and Franck Muller watches. His cell-phone, car's number plate and his own *bidi* brand, all end with 27, his lucky number.



▼ 70%